

---

# BRIDGEPOINTE

WHERE CRAFT MEETS HOME

---

Stripe Onboarding

## Owner Briefing

*Replacing QuickBooks for invoicing, payments,  
and bookkeeping — what to sign up for and why.*

---

Prepared for the owner · May 2026

---

---

**CONTENTS**

---

# What's inside

**I The Plan**

*Why we're moving off QuickBooks, and how Stripe replaces it.*

---

**II Signing Up at Stripe**

*Step-by-step at stripe.com — what to click, what to gather, what to send.*

---

**III How You'll Use It**

*The Monday-Friday operations runbook for you and Brenda.*

---

**IV Costs, FAQ & Risk**

*Real fee math, honest tradeoffs, and answers to the questions you'll have.*

---

*This briefing is prepared as a single document so you can read it in one sitting, sign up at Stripe, and send back the API keys to your stepson. Estimated reading time: 25 minutes.*

## SECTION I

# The Plan

## The plan in one paragraph

We are moving Bridgepointe Painting off QuickBooks Online. Going forward, your customers will pay their invoices by clicking a "Pay" button in the email you send them, instead of mailing you a paper check or calling Brenda for your address. The money lands in your business checking account in **2 business days**. Everything you do today inside QuickBooks — sending invoices, marking them paid, tracking who owes you what, pulling a customer statement — will happen inside your CRM at admin/, the same system that already runs your projects, customers, employees, and estimates. To actually move the money from the customer's card or bank into yours, the CRM uses Stripe. Stripe is the gold standard for online payments in the United States — almost every modern web business you have heard of (Amazon, Lyft, Shopify stores, virtually every contractor invoicing app on the market) runs on it. You will not log into Stripe day-to-day. You will log into the CRM the same way you do now.

## Why this is a good move for you

- **Lower processing fees on big jobs.** QuickBooks Payments charges **2.9% + 25¢** on every credit card payment and **1%** on every ACH bank transfer. Stripe charges **2.9% + 30¢** on cards (basically the same) but only **0.8% capped at \$5** on ACH. On a \$20,000 invoice paid by bank transfer that is the difference between **\$200** in QB fees and **\$5** in Stripe fees. You save **\$195 on that single payment**. With your average project at \$145,000 and a meaningful share of homeowners willing to pay by ACH when offered, the math gets serious fast.
- **Faster deposits.** Stripe is **2 business days** standard. QuickBooks is typically **3 to 5 days**. Send an invoice on Tuesday, get paid Tuesday night, money in your account Thursday.
- **Cancel the QuickBooks Online subscription.** Depending on your tier (Plus or Advanced), you are paying somewhere between **\$90 and \$235 per month** for QBO right now. That is **\$1,080 to \$2,820 per year** that goes away. QuickBooks Payments fees go away too — replaced by Stripe's lower rates.
- **One system, not two.** Right now, every invoice gets sent from QB and then either you or Brenda re-keys the project, the customer, and the line items into the CRM (or vice versa). After the switch, it is **one click in the CRM**. The invoice goes out, the payment comes in, the books update — all in one place. Brenda gets back several hours a week.
- **The customer experience is dramatically better.** Today, a homeowner in Brookhaven gets a paper invoice or a QB email, then has to dig out their checkbook, write the check, find a stamp, and mail it. After the switch, they click **"Pay \$14,500"** in their inbox, see a clean payment page with your logo on it, and pay with **Apple Pay, Google Pay, credit card, or a bank transfer** in under 60 seconds. No more "the check is in the mail" calls.

- **Your data stays yours.** The CRM owns the customer records, the invoices, the project history, the photos, the estimates. Stripe is a payment pipe — nothing more. If you ever want to switch payment processors down the road (PayPal, Square, your bank's merchant services), you can. Your customer history doesn't live on Stripe's servers — it lives on yours.
  - **Tax season gets simpler.** Stripe issues you a **1099-K** every January summarizing every dollar that came through it. The CRM tracks all your income and expenses next to each other, project by project. Your CPA can pull a clean CSV export of every transaction in seconds, instead of importing a tangled QB file.
- 

## How a payment will work, end to end

Here is exactly what happens, start to finish, on a typical job.

1. **Tuesday afternoon — you finish the Buckhead repaint.** Marcus and Patrick walk the job with the homeowner, get the sign-off, load the truck. You open the CRM on your phone in the driveway and mark the project complete.
  2. **You send the invoice.** Inside the CRM, you click "**Send Invoice**" on the project. The system pulls the line items straight from the estimate (interior walls, trim, two coats, ceiling repair on the dining room) and emails Mr. Smith a branded PDF invoice. Right at the top of that email is a big button that says "**Pay \$14,500**".
  3. **Mr. Smith clicks the button.** It opens a Stripe-hosted payment page in his browser. He sees the invoice line items, the total, the property address, your company logo at the top. He has three ways to pay: - Credit card — Visa, Mastercard, Amex, Discover - Bank transfer (ACH) — he picks his bank from a list, logs into his bank for a moment to authorize, and the transfer is set up - Apple Pay or Google Pay if he is on his phone
  4. **He pays.** Stripe runs the charge. He gets an instant email receipt with a PDF attached.
  5. **Your CRM updates within seconds.** Stripe automatically pings the CRM (this notification is called a "webhook" — it just means Stripe tells the CRM the moment a payment lands). The invoice flips from "**Outstanding**" to "**Paid**". Brenda sees it green-checked in the morning. Nothing for her to do.
  6. **The money lands in your bank.** Stripe deposits the funds into your business checking account **2 business days later** (Thursday). On your bank statement it shows up as a single deposit labeled "**STRIPE TRANSFER**" with the date.
  7. **Done.** No follow-up calls. No "did you get my check?" No re-keying anything into QB. No reconciliation drama at month-end.
-

## What replaces what

| What you used QuickBooks for                    | What replaces it                                                                                                                                                                      |
|-------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Sending invoices                                | The CRM (admin/invoices/)                                                                                                                                                             |
| Tracking customers and their balances           | The CRM (admin/customers/)                                                                                                                                                            |
| Tracking subcontractors and vendors             | The CRM (admin/vendors/)                                                                                                                                                              |
| Recording payments                              | Automatic — Stripe tells the CRM the instant money arrives                                                                                                                            |
| Customer statements                             | The CRM (auto-generated, one click to email or PDF)                                                                                                                                   |
| Estimates and proposals                         | The CRM (admin/estimates/)                                                                                                                                                            |
| Bills (subcontractor invoices coming in to you) | The CRM (admin/projects/{id}/bills/)                                                                                                                                                  |
| Chart of accounts                               | The CRM (admin/accounts/) — currently mirrored from QB; will become standalone                                                                                                        |
| Payroll                                         | <b>Still needs a separate tool.</b> We recommend Gusto — about <b>\$40/month + \$6/employee</b> . With ~10 employees that's roughly <b>\$100/month</b> . QB Payroll can be cancelled. |
| Sales tax filing                                | Stripe Tax — built in, <b>\$0 base + 0.5% per transaction</b>                                                                                                                         |
| Year-end 1099 generation                        | Stripe issues 1099-K to you automatically; CRM exports 1099-NEC for your subs                                                                                                         |
| Bank reconciliation                             | Stripe dashboard plus your bank statement directly. Simpler than QB's three-way match.                                                                                                |
| Profit and loss reports                         | Coming in CRM Phase 4 (~30 days from go-live)                                                                                                                                         |

## The honest tradeoffs

**What you give up.** QuickBooks has had 30 years to add features for small contractors. There are some niche things — handwritten estimates printed on custom paper sizes, integrations with specific local Atlanta software, a particular report format your old bookkeeper used — that won't have a one-click replacement on day one. We will build the things you actually use. If you tell me there is a QB feature you cannot live without, we will plan it. The good news is, after watching you work for the last six months, the list of things you genuinely use in QB is much shorter than the list of things QB advertises.

**What changes about your CPA relationship.** Your CPA is probably used to importing a QuickBooks company file at year-end. Tell them now, in May, that we are switching by fall — that gives them six months of runway.

They will adapt. Any decent CPA in 2026 already works with several Stripe-based businesses; this is not exotic. The CRM exports a CSV of every transaction (date, customer, project, amount, fees, net deposit), which is what your CPA actually needs for a Schedule C and a sales tax return. If your CPA pushes back hard, that is a sign they are not investing in modern bookkeeping tools, and you may want to find a CPA who has already worked with Stripe-native contractors. Most have.

---

## Timeline

The doc you are holding is dated for the start of May 2026. Here is how the rollout looks from here.

- **This week (May 6 onward):** You sign up at stripe.com and complete identity verification. Section II walks through every screen, every box, every button click. Allow 30–45 minutes.
  - **Within 1 week of approval:** Your stepson wires your approved Stripe account into the CRM. This is a one-time technical setup on his end — a few hours of work — and you don't have to do anything for it.
  - **Mid-May to early June (parallel run):** Keep using QuickBooks for the older invoices that are already out the door. Send any **new** invoices through the CRM. Pick a friendly customer for the first one — somebody patient who will tell you if anything looks weird on their end. By the second or third invoice it will feel routine.
  - **June through July:** Once you are comfortable, stop creating new invoices in QB entirely. Existing QB invoices finish through QB so you don't disrupt customers mid-stream.
  - **~60 days from your Stripe sign-up (early July):** Cancel the QuickBooks Online subscription. Cancel QuickBooks Payments. Done.
- 

## What this section covers vs the rest

This section is the big-picture plan. The rest of the document fills in the details. **Section II** is the step-by-step walkthrough of signing up at Stripe — exactly what to type into each box, what documents to have ready, what to expect in your inbox afterward. **Section III** is the day-to-day operations runbook — how you and Brenda will actually use the CRM to send invoices, look up payments, refund a customer, and run a monthly close, with screenshots from the live system. **Section IV** is the money: full cost breakdown, side-by-side comparison with what you pay today, frequently asked questions, and what to do if something goes wrong (a card gets declined, a customer disputes a charge, a deposit looks off). Read Sections II–IV in order when you are ready to act.

SECTION II

---

# Signing Up at Stripe

This section walks you through creating a Stripe account for Bridgepointe Painting from scratch. Follow it in order. If something on the screen doesn't quite match what's written here, that's fine — Stripe occasionally tweaks button wording, but the order and the information they ask for stays the same. When in doubt, look for the button that does what the step says it should do.

Plan to set aside 30 to 45 uninterrupted minutes. Have your stepson or your friend on speakerphone if you want a second set of eyes, but you can absolutely do this alone.

---

## Before you start (gather these documents)

Get all of this in front of you BEFORE you click anything. The activation form is one long flow, and if you have to stop halfway through to dig up your EIN letter, you'll lose your place.

- **Business legal name** — exactly as it appears on your LLC paperwork (probably "Bridgepointe Painting LLC" or similar). Punctuation matters. If there's a comma, include it.
- **Federal EIN** — your 9-digit IRS tax ID. You'll find it on the LLC's articles of organization, on any past IRS letter, or on last year's tax return.
- **Business address** — the address registered with the IRS for the LLC, not necessarily your home. This must match IRS records exactly.
- **Phone number** — the business line, or your personal mobile if that's what customers use.
- **Personal SSN of the principal owner** — yes, your own Social Security Number. Stripe is required by federal law to verify a real human is behind every business account, even an LLC. This is called KYC (Know Your Customer) and is non-negotiable.
- **Personal date of birth and home address** — yours, the owner's.
- **Business bank account routing number and account number** — the routing number is 9 digits, on the bottom-left of a check. The account number is the longer number to the right of it. This is where Stripe will deposit your money.
- **A driver's license or passport** — Stripe sometimes asks for a photo ID upload. Usually they don't, but if your EIN doesn't match IRS records cleanly, they will.
- **Estimated annual revenue** — a rough number for the past year. You can ballpark it; nobody's going to audit you.

**Tip:** Make a folder on your laptop called "Stripe Signup" and drop in PDFs of your EIN letter, articles of organization, and a voided check. If Stripe asks for these later, you'll have them ready in 30 seconds.

## Step 1 — Create the account

1. Open a browser tab and go to **stripe.com**.
2. Click the **Start now** button in the top-right corner of the page. Depending on which version of the homepage Stripe is showing, the button may say **Sign up** or **Get started** instead — they all go to the same place.
3. You'll see a signup form. Fill in: - **Email** — use a business email if you have one (something like `billing@bridgepointepainting.com`). Avoid a personal Gmail if you can help it. - **Full name** — your full legal name, as it appears on your driver's license. - **Country** — United States. - **Password** — make it strong. If you don't already use a password manager, this is a great moment to start. Recommend 1Password or Bitwarden. Do not reuse a password you use anywhere else.
4. Check the box agreeing to the Stripe Services Agreement.
5. Click **Create account**.
6. Stripe will send a verification email. Open your inbox, find the email from Stripe, and click the **Verify email** button inside it.
7. After verification, you'll land in the Stripe Dashboard at `dashboard.stripe.com`. **Bookmark this page now**. This is where you'll go forever afterward to check on payments, look up customers, and pull reports.

**Tip:** If the verification email doesn't show up in 2 minutes, check your spam folder, then click the "Resend verification email" link in the Dashboard.

## Step 2 — Activate your account (the longer form)

After you log in for the first time, you'll see a panel near the top of the Dashboard that says something like "Continue your activation" or "Activate your account." Click into it.

This is the part that takes 20 to 30 minutes. It's one connected form across about 8 screens. Stripe needs all of this to comply with banking regulations — they can't deposit money into your account without verifying who you are and what your business does. You can save and come back, but try to do it in one sitting.

### Business details

- **Type of business:** choose **Company**, then on the next screen pick **LLC** (or the entity type your LLC is registered as).



- **Industry:** choose **Construction services**, **Building and trade services**, or **Home services** — whichever appears in their dropdown. **Important: do not pick "Other."** Stripe gets nervous when businesses pick "Other" and will ask follow-up questions.
- **Business website:** enter `bridgepointepainting.com`. If your site isn't live yet, a Facebook business page URL works temporarily, but a real website is much better.
- **Product description:** one clear sentence: "Residential painting and home remodeling services in Atlanta, GA."

## Tax info

- **EIN:** your 9-digit number, no dashes.
- **Legal business name:** must match the IRS letter exactly, character for character. If your LLC is "Bridgepointe Painting, LLC" with a comma, include the comma.
- **Business address:** street, city, state, ZIP — must match what the IRS has on file.

## Personal verification (the principal owner)

Stripe legally has to verify a real human is behind the account. This is required for every Stripe account in the United States.

- **Full legal name** — yours.
- **Date of birth.**
- **Home address** — your actual residence, not the business address.
- **Last 4 digits of SSN** — Stripe asks for this. If verification fails, they'll come back and ask for the full 9 digits, which is normal.
- **Title at the company** — Owner, Member, or President. Pick whichever matches your LLC paperwork.
- **Ownership percentage** — if you're the sole owner, enter 100%.

## Bank account

- **Routing number:** 9 digits, on the bottom-left of a paper check.
- **Account number:** the longer number to the right of the routing number.
- **Account type:** **Checking.**
- **Use the business checking account, not your personal account.** This keeps your books clean and makes life much easier at tax time.

## Customer support

This is the contact information customers see if they have questions about a charge.

- **Support email:** your business email, or a dedicated one like `billing@bridgepointepainting.com`.

- **Support phone:** your existing business number.
- **Statement descriptor:** 22 characters maximum, this is what shows up on your customer's credit card statement. Recommend BRIDGEPOINTE PAINT or BRIDGEPOINTE ATL. A clear descriptor prevents customers from disputing charges they don't recognize.
- **Shortened descriptor:** 5 to 22 characters. BRIDGEPOINTE works fine.

## Two-factor authentication

Stripe will require two-factor authentication (2FA). Don't skip this; don't pick the easy option.

**Warning:** Use an **authenticator app** — Google Authenticator, Authy, or 1Password's built-in TOTP feature. **Do not use SMS text messages.** SMS-based 2FA can be defeated by SIM swap attacks, where a criminal calls your phone carrier, pretends to be you, and ports your number to their phone. Once they have your number, they can drain your Stripe account. App-based 2FA is far safer.

When Stripe shows the QR code, scan it with your authenticator app and enter the 6-digit code. Stripe will then give you **backup codes** — a list of 8 to 10 one-time-use codes. **Save these in your password manager immediately.** If you ever lose your phone, those codes are the only way back into your account.

---

## Step 3 — Submit for review

At the end of the activation flow, click **Submit application** (or **Activate account** — same button, sometimes labeled differently).

Stripe runs verification in the background. Most US small businesses with clean paperwork are approved within a few minutes. If Stripe needs more, they'll email you. Common requests:

- A copy of your EIN letter (IRS Form SS-4 or CP 575)
- Your articles of organization
- A voided check
- A photo of your driver's license

If you have those PDFs in the "Stripe Signup" folder we mentioned at the start, you can upload in 60 seconds. Most cases that need extra documents are resolved within 1 to 2 business days.

---

## Step 4 — Enable the right payment methods

Once approved, look at the left sidebar of the Dashboard. Click **Settings**, then **Payment methods**. Toggle these on:

- **Cards** — Visa, Mastercard, American Express, Discover. These are on by default; just verify they're enabled.
- **Apple Pay** and **Google Pay** — turn these on. They boost checkout completion by 10 to 15% because customers don't have to type in card numbers.
- **ACH Direct Debit** — US bank transfers. **Turn this on.** This is critical. ACH transactions cost roughly 0.8% capped at \$5, versus around 2.9% + 30¢ for cards. For larger invoices, this is the single biggest fee saver in the whole setup.
- **Link by Stripe** — Stripe's saved-payment-methods feature. Turn it on.
- **Skip:** Alipay, WeChat Pay, and other international wallets, unless you suddenly start getting customers from China.

---

## Step 5 — Enable Invoicing

In the left sidebar, click **Products**, then **Invoicing**, then **Activate**.

This turns on Stripe's hosted invoice pages, which is what your CRM will use to send professional invoices. There's no extra cost on top of the standard processing fees. Free to activate.

---

## Step 6 — Enable Stripe Tax (optional but recommended)

In the left sidebar, click **Products**, then **Tax**, then **Get started**.

Stripe Tax adds 0.5% per transaction. In return, Stripe automatically calculates and collects the correct sales tax on every invoice based on the customer's billing address.

For Georgia residential painting, sales tax rules are quirky — labor is typically exempt, but materials are taxable, and the rules differ if the work is considered a capital improvement. Having Stripe handle it for 0.5% is almost always worth it. Talk to your CPA to confirm.

---

## Step 7 — Stripe Connect (skip for now)

A note. **Stripe Connect** is a separate product designed for marketplaces — companies like Uber that pay out to drivers. For Bridgepointe v1, **you do not need Connect**. Your business receives all payments directly into your business bank account.

If, down the road, you add a feature where customers pay subcontractors directly through your CRM, we'd enable Connect at that point. For now, leave it alone — it adds complexity you don't need.

## Step 8 — Save the API keys (this is what your stepson needs)

In the left sidebar, click **Developers**, then **API keys**. You'll see two values:

- **Publishable key** — starts with `pk_live_...` (or `pk_test_...` in test mode). Safe to share. Used in the front-end of your CRM.
- **Secret key** — starts with `sk_live_...` (or `sk_test_...`). **NEVER share in plain text.** Treat it like a password. If it leaks, anyone who has it can refund payments and pull customer data.

There are two complete sets of keys: **Test mode** (toggle at the top of the Dashboard) and **Live mode**. Use Test mode keys while your stepson is setting up the CRM. Switch to Live mode keys only when you're ready to take real money.

***Warning:** Send the Live mode Secret key to your stepson via a password manager (1Password shared vault is ideal) or an encrypted message — **never plain email or text message**. A leaked secret key is an emergency.*

He'll plug both keys into the CRM's environment variables on Vercel.

---

## Step 9 — Set up the webhook

A "webhook" is the mechanism Stripe uses to notify your CRM the instant a payment happens. Without it, your CRM wouldn't know an invoice got paid until you logged in and refreshed.

In the left sidebar, click **Developers**, then **Webhooks**, then **Add an endpoint**.

- **Endpoint URL:** `https://bridgepointepainting.com/api/stripe/webhook`
- **Events to send:** select **All events**. The CRM will filter on its own side.
- Click **Add endpoint**.
- After it's created, you'll see a value labeled **Signing secret**, starting with `whsec_...`. Click to reveal and copy it.

Send the signing secret to your stepson the same secure way you sent the API keys.

---

## What to expect after signing up

- **First payouts are delayed.** Stripe holds your first few transactions for about 7 days as a fraud-prevention buffer. After that, deposits arrive on a 2-business-day rolling schedule.
- **Test mode is free forever.** Run as many fake payments as you want at zero cost. Use this to verify the CRM is working end-to-end before flipping to Live mode.
- **Monthly fee statements arrive by email.** Save these. Your CPA will want them at year-end.

- **Disputes happen.** Occasionally a customer will dispute a charge with their bank. Stripe will email you and give you a chance to respond with documentation (the signed contract, photos of completed work). Respond promptly.
- 

## Common gotchas

- **The address on Stripe MUST match the IRS exactly.** Even tiny differences — "Street" vs "St", "Suite 200" vs "Ste 200", an extra comma — can fail Stripe's automated verification. Copy the address character-for-character from your most recent IRS letter.
- **The bank account name must match the legal business name.** If your LLC is registered as "Bridgepointe Painting, LLC" but your bank has the account under "Bridgepointe Painting LLC" without the comma, Stripe's automated check may fail. Fix it by either updating the bank's record or asking the bank to issue a short letter confirming both names refer to the same entity.
- **Stripe sometimes asks for additional documents.** Articles of organization, EIN letter (IRS Form CP 575 or SS-4), a voided check. Have these ready as PDFs.
- **Don't lose your authenticator app.** If you switch phones or your phone breaks and you didn't save the backup codes, you'll be locked out of Stripe and recovery takes days. Save the backup codes in 1Password the moment Stripe gives them to you.
- **Don't skip the bookmark.** `dashboard.stripe.com` is your home base.

SECTION III

---

# How You'll Use It

This section is the operations runbook for Bridgepointe Painting after the Stripe integration goes live. It covers the actual buttons Brenda will click and the actual decisions you (the owner) will make Monday through Friday. The CRM lives at **bridgepointepainting.com/admin**, and Brenda has admin access.

The goal of this section is simple: by the end of it, you should both feel like there is no mystery left. Every common task — sending an invoice, recording a check, refunding a customer, responding to a chargeback — has a five-step procedure you can run without thinking.

---

## Your daily 5-minute routine (Brenda)

The morning rhythm:

1. Open the CRM at **/admin/invoices**.
2. Look for invoices that flipped to **Paid** overnight. The payment data auto-filled itself from Stripe — there is no work to do. Just notice they came in.
3. Glance at **/admin/integrations/quickbooks/sync-log** to confirm there are no sync errors. This step stays in place during the parallel-run period only; after we cut QuickBooks loose, this step disappears.
4. If any invoices are 7 or more days past due, click **Send Reminder**. The CRM resends the original payment link, and the email subject line gets "REMINDER" added in front.

That is the entire daily routine. Five minutes. Compare that to the previous workflow — download QuickBooks transactions, hand-mark each invoice paid, reconcile against the bank statement, hope the deposits matched — and the daily time savings are significant. Brenda gets her mornings back.

---

## Sending an invoice (the most common task)

This is the task you will do dozens of times a month. We will walk through it with a real example: Mr. Thompson, 1842 Briarcliff Rd, full exterior repaint in Buckhead, \$14,500.

1. In the CRM, go to **/admin/projects** and pick the Thompson project. (Alternatively, **/admin/invoices/new** lets you create a one-off invoice that is not tied to a project — useful for small touch-ups.)
2. On the project page, click **Create Invoice**.
3. The line items prefill from the project's signed estimate. Review them. Adjust quantities or descriptions if anything changed during the job.

4. Pick the **Customer** from the dropdown, or click + **Create new** if Mr. Thompson is a brand-new customer record. The customer record holds his email — Stripe needs that to deliver the payment link.
5. Set the **Issue Date** (defaults to today) and the **Due Date** (defaults to Net 15, but you can change to Net 30 or "Due on receipt" per job).
6. Add **Notes** if there is something to say. For Mr. Thompson, maybe: "Thanks for your patience while we waited out the rain on the second coat."
7. Click **Save & Send**.
8. Two things happen instantly: - Mr. Thompson gets a branded email from "Bridgepointe Painting" with the PDF invoice attached and a large gold **Pay \$14,500** button. - The invoice appears in **/admin/invoices** with status **Sent**.

*Tip: in the email, Mr. Thompson sees a "Save this card for next time" option if he pays by card. Repeat customers — and you have a lot of them, year after year — never have to re-enter their card info on the touch-up job next spring.*

---

## Recording a non-Stripe payment (cash, check, in-person)

A meaningful chunk of your customer base — especially older homeowners — will keep handing the foreman a check at the end of the job. The CRM handles that gracefully:

1. Open the invoice in the CRM.
2. Click **Record Payment**.
3. Pick the payment method: **Check, Cash, Wire transfer, ACH (manual), or Other**.
4. Enter the amount and the date you received the payment.
5. Add a memo if useful, like "Check #1247" or "Cash handed to foreman 5/4".
6. Save.

The invoice flips to **Paid** with the manual payment record attached. The bank deposit happens the way it always has — Brenda or the foreman walks the check to the bank. The CRM is tracking the fact that you got paid; it is not pretending Stripe processed something it did not. This keeps the books honest.

---

## Issuing a refund

Refunds will be rare, but they happen — color complaints, scope reduction after the job started, occasional customer disputes you decide to settle:

1. Open the invoice in the CRM.
2. Click **Refund**.

3. Enter the refund amount. You can issue a full refund or a partial refund (for example, \$500 off a \$14,500 job for a touch-up they did not love).
4. Add a reason if you want it in your records.
5. Click **Confirm**.

The CRM tells Stripe to issue the refund. Stripe pulls the money from your next payout. The customer sees the refund on their card or bank statement within 5 to 10 business days.

***Warning:** refunds count against your Stripe processing volume, and the original 2.9% + 30¢ processing fee is **not** returned to you. For partial scope changes, it is usually cleaner to issue a credit memo (a feature we will add in Phase 4) than to refund and re-invoice.*

---

## Handling a dispute (chargeback)

A dispute happens when a customer's bank reverses a charge against you. Usually the cause is one of two things: the customer did not recognize the bank-statement descriptor ("BRIDGEPOINTE PAINT"), or they are claiming the work was not completed. You have **20 days** from the dispute notice to respond with evidence.

When a dispute hits, the CRM displays a banner: "**Dispute opened on Invoice #INV-2026-0142 — respond by [date].**"

1. Click the banner. The CRM links straight through to the Stripe Dashboard's dispute response page.
2. Stripe asks for: a description of the work performed, the signed estimate, before-and-after photos (the crew portal already collected these — this is exactly why we built it), the customer's communication history, and the invoice itself.
3. The CRM has 90% of this material ready. Pull the photos from **/admin/projects/[id]/photos**, the signed estimate from **/admin/estimates/**, and the invoice PDF from the invoice record.
4. Submit through Stripe.
5. Stripe arbitrates with the bank. A decision typically arrives in 60 to 75 days.

Most disputes go in your favor when you have crew photos showing the work was done. **This is one of the biggest reasons we built the crew photo system** — it is your single best defense against frivolous chargebacks.

---

## Recurring customers (year-over-year)

A huge part of your business is repeat work. Mr. Thompson asks for a touch-up next spring — here is the friction:

1. Find Thompson at **/admin/customers/**.
2. Click **New Project**. The project is automatically linked to his customer record.



3. When you invoice him, his email is already filled in.
4. He gets the email, clicks Pay. If he saved his card last time via Stripe Link, the card autofills.

Roughly 30 seconds of friction for a returning customer. Compare to the old workflow — print the invoice, mail it, wait for the check, deposit the check, mark it paid in QuickBooks. That is days of float and a real chance the check gets lost or forgotten.

---

## Monthly close (Brenda's first-of-month routine)

The bookkeeping rhythm at the start of each month:

1. **Reconcile:** open the Stripe Dashboard, go to **Payments**, filter to the previous month. The total should match what the CRM shows under **/admin/reports/cash-flow** (coming in Phase 4).
2. **Bank deposit check:** open the business checking account online statement. Every Stripe deposit should show up as a **STRIPE TRANSFER** line. If a transfer is missing, check Stripe's **Payouts** tab for that date — sometimes a payout takes the rolling 2 business days plus a weekend.
3. **Export for the CPA:** in the CRM, go to **/admin/reports/profitability** (coming) and click **Export CSV**. Email it to your CPA.
4. **Cancel-the-old-thing check:** during the parallel-run period, note any QuickBooks invoices still open that need to be closed out manually. After 60 days, none should remain.

---

## When something goes wrong

A short troubleshooting guide for the things that actually happen:

- **A customer says "the link doesn't work":** open the invoice in the CRM and click **Resend Payment Link**. If it still fails, ask which browser or device they're using. Stripe's pages work on every modern browser, but some corporate networks block the page entirely — in that case have them try from their phone on cellular.
- **A payment looks stuck on Processing:** ACH transfers take 3 to 5 business days to clear, so this is normal for ACH. Card payments are usually instant. If a card payment is showing **Processing** for more than an hour, look up the charge ID in the Stripe Dashboard and check the status there.
- **Stripe emails about a "verification request":** Stripe occasionally asks for additional documentation — an updated EIN letter, proof of business address, an updated ID for the account owner. Respond within 7 days or the account gets paused. If you are not sure what they want, forward the email to your stepson.
- **A customer wants to pay over the phone:** do not take the card number verbally. It puts you out of PCI compliance. Instead, send the invoice email — they pay through Stripe's PCI-compliant page. If the customer truly insists, the Stripe Dashboard has a manual **Charge a card** button under **Payments** → **New**, and you can type the card number directly into Stripe.

## What the customer experiences (for empathy)

It helps to know what the other side of this looks like:

The customer receives an email titled "Invoice from Bridgepointe Painting — \$14,500". It is branded with your logo. The subject line is something like "Invoice for the Buckhead repaint." The body has a short note from you (auto-generated but customizable per invoice), the invoice line items inline, and a single big **Pay** button.

When they click Pay:

- They land on a Stripe-hosted page at **pay.bridgepointepainting.com**. We set up a custom domain for the payment page so it reads as your brand, not stripe.com.
- They see the same line items, the total, your logo.
- They pick a payment method — card, ACH, or saved card via Stripe Link.
- They pay.
- They get an instant receipt email.
- Optionally, they save the card for next year's touch-up.

The whole thing takes about 60 seconds. No checks, no envelopes, no "the check is in the mail."

---

## Phase 4 features that come next (in the CRM)

A quick preview of what is on the roadmap so you know where we are headed:

- **Profit & Loss report:** live, no QuickBooks needed.
- **Balance sheet:** live.
- **Cash flow forecast:** 30, 60, and 90 day predictions based on outstanding invoices and historical pay-times.
- **1099-NEC generation:** for subcontractors at year-end. No more chasing TINs in January.
- **Tax exports:** clean CSVs for the CPA, mapped to standard tax categories.
- **Recurring invoices:** for the maintenance contracts — annual touch-ups, pressure washing memberships, deck refinish reminders.

## SECTION IV

## Costs, FAQ & Risk

This section is the honest money conversation. What Stripe costs. What QuickBooks costs today. What you actually save. Where the risks are. What we need from you to get this off the ground.

No spin. Real numbers.

### Cost comparison

#### Stripe pricing (2026)

| Payment method                   | Fee                                        | Capped?              |
|----------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|----------------------|
| Card (Visa, MC, Amex, Discover)  | <b>2.9% + \$0.30</b> per successful charge | No                   |
| Card-present (in-person)         | 2.7% + \$0.05                              | No                   |
| ACH Direct Debit (bank transfer) | <b>0.8%</b>                                | <b>Yes — \$5 max</b> |
| Apple Pay / Google Pay           | Same as card (2.9% + \$0.30)               | No                   |
| International cards              | +1.5%                                      | No                   |
| Stripe Tax (optional)            | +0.5% per transaction                      | No                   |
| Disputes (lost)                  | \$15 fee per dispute                       | —                    |
| Refunds                          | Original processing fee NOT returned       | —                    |
| Monthly fee                      | <b>\$0</b>                                 | —                    |

Two things to notice. First, the ACH cap at **\$5**. That alone is the single biggest fee win for a contractor with \$5K–\$50K invoices. Second, there is no monthly fee. You only pay when money moves.

## QuickBooks Online + QB Payments (current)

| Item                                                        | Cost                                     |
|-------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|
| QuickBooks Online Plus (typical for a contractor this size) | \$99/month = <b>\$1,188/year</b>         |
| Or QuickBooks Online Advanced                               | \$235/month = \$2,820/year               |
| QB Payments — Card                                          | 2.9% + \$0.25 per transaction            |
| QB Payments — ACH                                           | 1% (capped at \$10)                      |
| QB Payroll (if used)                                        | \$50–\$95/month base + \$6–\$12/employee |

QB card pricing is a hair cheaper per transaction (\$0.25 vs \$0.30 fixed fee). The difference vanishes the moment your average invoice exceeds about \$200, which it always does for you. The ACH gap is wider: 1% capped at \$10 vs 0.8% capped at \$5. Stripe wins ACH on every invoice over \$625.

## Real annual savings calculation

Here's the math in plain language. The assumptions are conservative on purpose — if anything, the real numbers will be better.

- **Annual revenue assumption:** \$1.2M (240 jobs × \$5K avg invoice — most jobs are split into 2–3 invoices, so the per-invoice average is much lower than the \$145K per-job average)
- **Mix assumption:** 30% paid by card, 60% paid by ACH/check, 10% other
- **Card volume:** \$360,000/yr → 0% change in fees (Stripe and QB are basically tied: 2.9% vs 2.9%)
- **ACH volume:** \$720,000/yr
- **QB ACH:** 1% capped at \$10. Avg invoice \$5K means the \$10 cap hits on every single ACH payment → ~\$1,440/yr in fees (\$10 × ~144 ACH invoices)
- **Stripe ACH:** 0.8% capped at \$5. Same invoice flow → ~\$720/yr in fees
- **ACH savings:** ~\$720/yr
- **QB subscription:** \$99–\$235/month canceled = ~**\$1,200–\$2,800/yr saved**
- **Time saved by Brenda** (no manual reconciliation): conservatively 2 hours/week × \$30/hr loaded = **\$3,000/yr saved in office time**
- **Faster cash collection** (Stripe deposits 2 days vs QB 3–5): on \$1.2M revenue, ~\$10K of working capital freed up earlier = **\$300/yr in financing benefit at 3% short-term cost of capital**

**Total realistic annual savings: \$5,200 – \$6,800**

But here's the thing. The dollar number is real but it's not the point. The bigger value is operational. Brenda doesn't chase invoice payments anymore — the system does. Customers actually pay (because it's a click in an email, not a "log in to QuickBooks customer portal" experience). The CRM becomes the single source of truth for

revenue, which means at year-end you and your CPA aren't reconciling two systems that don't agree. That's worth more than the dollar savings.

---

## What about the QB subscription — when do I cancel?

Don't cancel QuickBooks Day 1. That would be reckless. You need to keep QB running through three milestones, in order:

1. **All invoices created in QB have been paid or written off.** Give yourself 60 days from cutover. Anything still open after 60 days is either getting paid offline (record it manually) or it's never getting paid (write it off).
2. **Year-end 1099-NEC forms have been issued for any subs paid through QB this calendar year.** This is the IRS deadline of January 31 of the following year. If you cut over in October 2026, you'll still need QB through end of January 2027 to issue the 1099s for 2026 sub payments that ran through QB.
3. **Your CPA has the QB data export they need for the prior year.** Ask the CPA what format they want before you cancel. Most want the QBO file plus PDFs of the year-end P&L and balance sheet.

Once those three are done, cancel. Save the QB exports as PDFs and CSVs in a permanent archive folder on Google Drive. If anyone ever audits 2024–2026, you have it. You don't need to keep paying QB \$99/month for read-only access to data you've already exported.

---

## Risks and mitigations

Here's the honest list of things that could go wrong and what we do about each.

### "What if Stripe locks my account?"

It happens. Stripe has been known to freeze accounts for 30+ days when a sudden transaction pattern looks suspicious — large infrequent charges from a brand-new account is exactly the pattern that trips their fraud system. **Mitigations:**

- Tell Stripe upfront what your business does (large infrequent invoices for residential construction). There's a free-text field during sign-up for this. Stripe is fine with construction — it's their bread and butter for B2B and home services.
- Don't run a sudden burst of large card transactions in week 1. Start with smaller invoices, ramp up over the first month.
- Keep ~2 weeks of operating cash in a separate account so a payout pause doesn't cripple operations. (You should be doing this anyway, with or without Stripe.)
- **Backup processor:** open a Square account too (free, takes 10 minutes). Never use it unless Stripe has an issue. It's insurance, not a primary tool.

### "What if my CPA doesn't like this?"

Most CPAs working with construction businesses now use Stripe-native exports — Stripe is bigger than QB Payments at this point and every accounting firm has seen it. If yours hasn't:

- Show them the CSV export from the CRM. It includes every invoice, every payment, every fee, every refund — everything they need.
- If they insist on QuickBooks-format data, ask if they support the QBO export format (most CRMs can output it; we'll add it in Phase 4).
- Worst case: keep QB at the cheapest tier (~\$35/month for Simple Start) for the CPA's convenience, even after you migrate operations off it. \$420/year is cheap insurance against accountant friction.

### "What if the website goes down?"

The CRM runs on Vercel. Vercel has 99.99% uptime — that's about 53 minutes of downtime per year. If the CRM is down:

- Stripe payment pages still work. They're hosted by Stripe directly at stripe.com, not by us.
- Customers can still pay invoices that were already sent — the invoice email contains a Stripe-hosted link.
- The CRM catches up when it's back online. Stripe queues the webhook events and re-delivers them.

In practice you'd probably never notice an outage unless it happened during the exact minute you tried to log in.

### "What if Stripe doubles the fees overnight?"

They can. So can QB. So can any vendor. Mitigations:

- Read Stripe's monthly emails. Pricing changes get 30+ days advance notice.
- The CRM is processor-agnostic. If Stripe's pricing ever becomes uncompetitive, we can switch to Adyen, Authorize.net, or Square in 1–2 weeks of dev work. The customer experience doesn't change — they still click a link, still pay with a card or bank, still get a receipt. Only the back-end processor is different.

### "What if I don't trust putting my customers' card data in Stripe?"

Stripe is the most heavily-audited payment processor in the world. PCI Level 1 certified, SOC 2 Type II compliant, used by Amazon, Shopify, Lyft, Salesforce, and a long list of Fortune 500s. Your customers' card data is, statistically, safer at Stripe than it is in QB Payments (which is built on top of Intuit's older payment infrastructure).

The CRM never sees raw card numbers. They go directly from the customer's browser to Stripe — we get back a token that says "card ending in 4242, charged \$5,000." Even if someone hacked the CRM tomorrow, there are no card numbers to steal.

---

## FAQ

- 1. Can my customers still pay by check?** Yes. Mail a check, hand it to you on-site, whatever. You record the payment manually in the CRM. Stripe is just for the digital payments — the CRM tracks all payment methods equally.
- 2. Will my customers see "Stripe" on their statement?** No. They'll see whatever you set as the statement descriptor — recommend "BRIDGEPOINTE PAINT" or similar. Familiar to your customers. Stripe never shows up on their bank statement.
- 3. What if a customer pays the wrong amount?** Stripe accepts partial payments if you enable that on the invoice. Otherwise the customer can only pay the exact amount. We'll set it up to allow partial payments since construction often has progress invoicing — the customer might pay \$20K of a \$50K invoice as a milestone.
- 4. Can I take a deposit before starting work?** Yes. Issue an invoice for the deposit (e.g., 30%), they pay through Stripe, you start work. Issue final invoice for the balance when you finish. Both invoices live under the same job in the CRM, so you can see at a glance what's been collected and what's still owed.
- 5. What about international customers?** Stripe handles them automatically. The fee is +1.5% on top of the card fee. For a residential painting business in Atlanta this is rare, but if a snowbird from Ontario hires you to paint their second home, it just works.
- 6. What if I need to issue a 1099 for a subcontractor?** The CRM tracks every payment to every subcontractor by name and EIN. At year-end, the CRM exports a 1099-NEC ready file. (Phase 4, ~30 days out.) For now, run 1099s through QB while you transition.
- 7. What if I want a phone number to call Stripe at?** Stripe support is email + chat first, but they DO have phone support for businesses doing >\$10K/month — which you qualify for several times over. The phone number's in the Dashboard under Help. They actually answer.
- 8. Will my old QB customers automatically be in the new system?** Yes. We've built an import tool that pulls every QB customer into the CRM (Section IV of the QB integration document). This already works — we tested it on a sample export.
- 9. What if I want to go back to QB?** Easy. The CRM exports everything in QB-compatible CSV — customers, invoices, payments, refunds. You'd lose the Stripe payment integration but the data is yours. There's no lock-in.
- 10. Can I see a demo before signing up?** Yes. We can run Stripe in **test mode** indefinitely — fake card numbers (4242 4242 4242 4242 is the famous one), fake bank accounts, no real money moves. Try it, kick the tires, send yourself a fake invoice, then activate live mode when you're comfortable.

---

## What we need from you (action items)

- Confirm the LLC's exact legal name (must match IRS letter character-for-character)

- Get the EIN from the IRS letter or the CPA
- Confirm the business bank account (the one Stripe should deposit into) — routing and account number
- Sign up at [stripe.com](https://stripe.com) following Section II
- Send your stepson the API keys + webhook signing secret via 1Password (NOT email)
- Schedule a 30-minute call after sign-up to do the first test charge together
- Tell your CPA we're switching processors (so they're not surprised at year-end)
- Tell Brenda to read Section III before go-live

That's it. Eight items. Most of them take less than 5 minutes each. The Stripe sign-up itself is the longest item at 20–40 minutes.

---

## What we're NOT changing yet

End on the reassuring note. Things that are NOT changing:

- Your bank stays the same.
- Your customers stay the same — they don't have to do anything.
- The phone number stays the same.
- Your existing crew portal at `/portal` stays the same.
- QB stays running for ~60 days as a backup until you're comfortable.
- Your day-to-day work — quotes, jobs, crews — doesn't change at all.

The only thing changing is **how money flows in**. From "QuickBooks emails an invoice, customer logs into a portal, money lands in QB, money sweeps to bank" to "CRM emails an invoice, customer clicks a link, money lands at Stripe, money sweeps to bank." Same end result, fewer steps, lower fees, faster.

This is a controlled migration, not a leap.



---

# BRIDGEPOINTE

*Where Craft Meets Home*

Atlanta, Georgia

---

Stripe Onboarding Briefing · May 2026